Chapter One: The Beginning

The old house stood at the end of the lane, and nobody in the village could remember who had built it. The windows were dark and the garden had grown wild, but the gate still opened without a sound when Anna pushed it on that first cold morning.

She had come to the village because her aunt had left her the house, and because a word like hyphenated describes the way her life had been split in two. The lawyer had called it a well-known property, which made her laugh, since a well-known house would surely have a name.

Inside, the rooms smelled of dust and apples. Anna walked slowly from one to the next, touching the backs of chairs, and she decided before she reached the kitchen that she would stay.

Chapter Two: The Letter

On the second day a letter arrived. It had no stamp and no name on the envelope, only the words for the new owner written in careful blue ink across the front.

Anna read it twice standing in the hall. The writer asked her to look behind the third shelf in the study, where something had been waiting for a very long time.

She did not go at once. She made tea first, because her aunt had always said that nothing good ever came of hurrying, and then she carried the cup upstairs.

Chapter Three: Voices

"Who is there?" she asked.
"Only me," said a voice from the shelf.
"That is not an answer."
The voice laughed, and the sound of it was so warm and so ordinary that Anna found she was not afraid at all. She sat down on the top step and waited for the rest of the story.